Check for updates

Slow ecology

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Somewhere east of Tucson on Interstate-10 it began to rain, but we didn't ease up. We hurtled at full speed, buzzing on coffee, passing caravans of sixteen wheelers and blurred hills of ocotillo and mesquite. Our truck was loaded with wooden nest boxes for a field experiment to study solitary bees, which we had built with equal urgency. We had bored row after row of holes into beams of yellow pine with a drill bit spinning 1,500 revolutions per minute, sliced those beams into rectangular blocks with blades moving twice as fast, and stuffed the resulting six thousand nesting cavities with paper straws—all at a pace that suggested we were trying to set a new world record.

Our pace was justified. We had just three weeks to build the nest boxes in Chicago, drive 2,800 kilometers to Tucson, install the experiment in the desert mountains, and return home in time for the next tasks demanding our attention. As we sped along the highway, it occurred to us that although our frenetic pace felt motivated by our current circumstance, it also felt all too familiar. Our academic lives often feel like one big race to submit grants, collect data, publish papers, and then repeat the process. We reflected on what we might miss along the way—both on our road trip, but also in our practice as ecologists. Speed is an excellent choice if *productivity* is the goal, but what choices might we make if we placed equal value on *process*?

The processes that underpin our work as ecologists—curiosity, attention, inquiry, critical thinking, and reflection—are slow and non-linear, and they grow richer the longer we spend with them. For example, decoding the natural history of other organisms we've studied—why hummingbirds visit atypical flowers, why cellophane bees emerge over many years, why prairie smoke seedlings are so rare—required pursuing many foggy lines of inquiry before reaching clarity. Operating any faster would have risked overlooking the details that matter most. Certainly, like a river cutting downhill, swiftness is required for some tasks, but slowness creates still pools where ideas can hatch. It is impossible to wonder quickly about the natural world.

Yet, contemporary academia rewards speed; performance metrics emphasize production above all else. Expectations of publishing articles, reviewing submissions, submitting grants, mentoring students, answering emails, teaching courses, and reading an ever-growing mountain of literature create a real sense of urgency. Such a mindset makes it easy to forget the joy of taking one's time, or, even worse, to conclude that taking one's time is indulgent.

In a system that rewards speed, slowing down is an act of resistance—a choice to move at a different pace. Not to procrastinate, but rather to linger when it is necessary to linger. To sit with uncertainty for uncertainty's sake, instead of rushing to a conclusion. This is easier said than done, and we must do so carefully, and with intention—otherwise we risk rushing without even realizing we're rushing. It is a choice to roll up our pants, wade into those still pools, and remain open to whatever we might find.

As we installed the nest boxes at the field sites, we talked about how we might embody this mindset in the approaching field season. We would have to work efficiently to collect standardized, temporal data on solitary bees and manzanita flowers. But might we make time to pay attention to the other animals and plants that we work alongside? Might we journal at the end of the field day to record our thoughts and questions? Might we approach unexpected observations as doorways into curiosity?

The field season went fast, but not because we rushed. We gathered the data we needed, and we also stopped for sun dogs and shadows, for kinglets and towhees, for firecracker penstemons and the biggest grasshoppers we'd ever seen. We invited an artist and a class of students to join us in the field, and learned from their reactions and perspectives. We interacted with delightful strangers, including a hunter who taught us about why the timing of manzanita flowering matters to black bears. We journaled about everything. Our field notes eventually revealed intriguing observations about the desert grasslands: dietary specialist solitary bees gather pollen from unexpected plants; individual manzanita plants re-flower within the same year; and long-lived barrel cactus wear visible markers of their age. None of this is explicitly destined for a manuscript, and that is entirely the point.

Moving forward, our challenge will be to practice slowness in our daily work—in the field, in the classroom, and at our desks. To keep writing the papers and grants that inspire us most, but also to make time to string up our ideas around the room, stand back, and try to make sense of what it all means.

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